

C. 32—33 are assigned expressly (32, 2. 33, 1) to the period of Jeremiah's honourable confinement in the "court of the guard," *i.e.* to the second part of the siege, in Zedekiah's tenth year, after it had been interrupted by the temporary withdrawal of the Chaldeans: the composition of c. 30—31 belongs probably to the same time, though from the tenor of 30, 2 ("Write thee all *the words that I have spoken unto thee* in a book") it is more than possible that the contents had in part been originally uttered previously, but, as 32, 2 "then" shows, that they were not committed to writing till subsequently, probably after the fall of the city.

The chapters which follow are largely historical, though naturally confined to incidents in which Jeremiah was more or less directly concerned.

C. 34, 1—7 relates the message which Jeremiah was instructed to bear to Zedekiah respecting the future fate as well of the city as of the king himself.

The occasion was probably during the first investment of Jerusalem by the Chaldeans (Hitz. Keil, Kuen. PS.), a little subsequent to 21, 1—10; though others, from the fact that the prophecy is the one quoted in 32, 3—5 during the second part of the siege, have referred it by preference to this period (Ew. Graf).

34, 8—22. The inhabitants of Jerusalem, under pressure of the siege, had solemnly engaged to emancipate their Hebrew slaves; but afterwards, when the siege was temporarily raised, had treacherously disregarded the engagement. Jeremiah denounces them for their breach of faith, with bitter irony proclaiming "liberty" to the sword, the pestilence, and the famine, and declaring that the Chaldeans will ere long return, and not depart until they have reduced the city.

C. 35—36 bring us back into the reign of Jehoiakim. The date of c. 35 is towards the close of Jehoiakim's reign, when, the territory of Judah being overrun by marauding bands (2 Ki. 24, 2), the nomad tribe of Rechabites took refuge in Jerusalem: Jeremiah, from the example of their staunch adherence to the precepts of their ancestor, points a lesson for his own fellow-countrymen. C. 36 narrates the memorable incident of the fifth year of Jehoiakim, when the roll of Jeremiah's prophecies was burnt by the king in a fit of passion (p. 234).

C. 37—38 describe Jeremiah's personal history during the siege of Jerusalem by the Chaldeans (comp. p. 233 f.).

C. 39—43 state particulars respecting the events of Jeremiah's life after the capture of Jerusalem, the favour shown to him by

Nebuchadnezzar, the murder of Gedaliah, and the circumstances under which the prophet, against his will, was brought into Egypt: 43, 8-13 is a prophecy uttered by him upon the arrival of the refugees at Tahpanhes (Daphnae), declaring the future conquest of Egypt by Nebuchadnezzar.

39, 1-14 connects imperfectly with c. 38, v. 1 going back to the *beginning* of the siege. It seems (in spite of their being in the LXX) that the words in vv. 1-2 from *In the ninth year* to *in the city* (which cannot be legitimately treated as a parenthesis, as in RV.) are an interpolation on the basis of 52, 4. 6f. 39, 4-13 is omitted in LXX, and it is doubtful if it forms part of the original narrative: the connexion of v. 4 with v. 3 is imperfect, and in any case vv. 4-10 are merely *abridged* from 2 Ki. 25, 4-12 (comp. esp. v. 8 with 2 Ki. 25, 8-10), according to the purer and more original text still preserved in Jer. 52, 7-16. Most probably the original text had only 39, 1 (to *taken*). 3 [with *and* for *that*, as in the Heb.]. 14 [Heb. *and they sent*]: these words form a continuous narrative, the particulars in which are *not* borrowed from c. 52 (so Ew. Hitz. Graf, Kuen. Orelli,—Hitz. and Or., however, including v. 11 f. as well). 39, 15-18 is a supplement to c. 38, promising a reward to Ebed-melech on account of the services rendered by him to Jeremiah.

C. 44. Jeremiah here rebukes the fugitives in Egypt for relapsing into their old idolatries: they excuse themselves; the prophet, in reply, repeats his previous denunciations, declaring that of their entire body, a handful only should return into the land of Judah.

C. 45 is a short prophecy, containing words of mingled reassurance and reproof, addressed to Baruch in the depression and disappointment which overcame him, after writing the roll of the 4th year of Jehoiakim, at the near and certain prospect of his country's ruin. He is reminded that the age is one in which he must not expect great things for himself, but must be content if he escapes with his bare life.

C. 46-51 form the book of Jeremiah's prophecies concerning foreign nations, grouped together, as in the case of the similar prophecies in the Books of Isaiah (c. 13-23) and Ezekiel (c. 25-32). The prophecies are closely connected with c. 25 (most of the nations to which they refer being named in 25, 19-26), and indeed in the text of the LXX are inserted in it.¹

C. 46. On *Egypt*. This falls into two parts: (1) vv. 3-12 an

¹ They follow 25, 13, the words in 25, 13^b "which," &c., in the form, "The things which Jeremiah prophesied against the nations," forming a superscription; v. 14 being omitted; and vv. 15 (in the form, "Thus said Jehovah," &c.). 16-38 following at the end.

ode of triumph on the defeat of Pharaoh Necho at Carchemish (*v.* 2), B.C. 604; (2) *vv.* 14-26 a prophecy written in the same strain as *vv.* 3-12, foretelling the successful invasion of Egypt by Nebuchadnezzar.

V. 27 f. (words of reassurance addressed to Israel) are all but identical with 30, 10 f. They appear to imply that the captivity has *begun*, and it is at least doubtful (in spite of 3, 18, 16, 15) whether Jer. would have so expressed himself in B.C. 604. On the other hand, they are in their place in c. 30, which appears (*p.* 247) to have received its present form after the fall of Jerusalem. Perhaps they were attached here subsequently, either by Jer. himself, or by a reader, or editor, of his prophecies.

C. 47 is directed against the *Philistines*, indirectly also (*v.* 4) against Tyre and Sidon: their country is to be wasted by a foe whose attack is compared to waters rising up out of the north and inundating the land.

The foe meant is unquestionably the Chaldæans (*cf.* 13, 20, 25, 9, 46, 20), and the occasion is no doubt the same as that of c. 46. The note of time in *v.* 1^b is obscure; but probably the allusion is to a capture of Gaza by the Egyptians not otherwise known to us, either on their retreat from Carchemish, or possibly in connexion with the movements mentioned in 37, 5. The note *may*, however, be due to one who supposed the Egyptians to be meant in *v.* 2.

C. 48 is a long prophecy directed against *Moab*, for the inhabitants of which desolation and exile are foretold. The prophet develops his theme in considerable detail, in connexion with the topography of Moab: he closes, *v.* 47, with a prospect of restoration in the future.

The prophecy, esp. in *vv.* 29-38, has numerous reminiscences from Isaiah's prophecy (c. 15-16) on the same nation (see RV. *marg.*), but the style and manner of the whole are very different: the treatment is more diffuse; and it is marked by greater vehemence (*e.g.* *vv.* 10, 20 ff. 26, 39).

49, 1-6 is on the *Ammonites*, a prophecy of similar import to that on Moab, but briefer; *vv.* 7-22 are on *Edom*, whose mountain fortresses will form no protection against the attack of the Chaldæan king (figured by the "lion" of *v.* 19, and the "eagle" of *v.* 22); *vv.* 23-27 are on *Damascus*, whose warriors, when the critical moment arrives, will be seized with panic, and perish helplessly in the streets; *vv.* 28-33 are on the great pastoral (Is. 42, 11, 60, 7) tribe of *Kedar*, who are to be rudely disturbed in their security, and scattered "to every wind" by Nebuchadnezzar; *vv.* 34-39 are on *Elam* (assigned by the title to the beginning of the reign of Zedekiah), against which a fate similar to that of Kedar is predicted.

It is probable that all these prophecies, except the last, belong to the 4th year of Jehoiakim, and reflect the profound impression which Nebuchadnezzar's victory at Carchemish produced upon the prophet. On the remarkable similarities between the prophecy upon Edom and that of Obadiah, see below, under Obadiah. In the case of Ammon and Elam (49, 6. 39) the prophecy closes with a promise of restoration similar to that given to Moab (48, 47): comp. 12, 15 f.

C. 50—51. A long and impassioned prophecy against *Babylon*, 50, 1—51, 58, followed by a short historical notice, 51, 59—64^a, describing how, when Seraiah—probably the brother of Jeremiah's friend and assistant Baruch—in the 4th year of Zedekiah (B.C. 593) accompanied the king on a journey to Babylon, Jeremiah sent by his hand a scroll, containing a prophecy against the city, with instructions to read it upon his arrival there, and afterwards to sink it in the Euphrates, as a sign that Babylon would sink in like manner, and not rise again. The prophecy itself (50, 2 ff.) declares the approaching capture of Babylon, and the speedy end of the power of the Chaldæans; the time has come for the violence done by them to Israel to be requited (50, 11 f. 17—20. 33 f. 51, 5. 24. 34 f. 44. 56); a people from the north, even the Medes, are about to be "stirred up" (cf. Is. 13, 17) against them (50, 3. 9. 25. 41 ff. 51, 2. 11. 20—23 [Cyrus]); again and again the prophet with eager vehemence invites the foe to begin the fray (50, 14—16. 21. 26 f. 51, 11 f. 27 f.), while he bids the exiles escape betimes from the doomed city (50, 8. 51, 6. 45 f. 50), the future fate of which he contemplates with manifest delight (50, 2^b. 13. 23 f. 35—38. 46. 51, 13 f. 25 ff. 30 ff. 33 ff. 47 ff.).

It does not seem that this prophecy (50, 1—51, 58) is Jeremiah's. The grounds for this conclusion do not consist in the announcement *per se* which the prophecy contains of the end of the Babylonian power—for this was certainly foreseen by Jer. (25, 12. 27, 7. 22. 29, 10)—or in the phraseology, which has much in common with Jer.'s; but in the *manner* in which the announcement is made, and especially in the contradiction which it evinces with the position which Jer. is known to have taken in the year to which it is assigned by 51, 59. (1) The standpoint of the prophecy is later than Zedekiah's 4th year. The destruction of the *Temple* is presupposed (50, 28. 51, 11. 51); the Jews are in exile, suffering for their sins (50, 4 f. 7. 17. 33. 51, 34 f. "hath made me *an empty vessel*"); but Jehovah is now ready to pardon and deliver them (50, 20. 34. 51, 33^b. 36); the hour of retribution is at hand for their foes, and they themselves are bidden prepare to leave Babylon (see the passages cited above). But in B.C. 593 it was the measure of *Israel's* wickedness which, in Jer.'s estimation, was not yet filled up; the Chaldæans had yet to complete against Jerusalem the work allotted to them